

EWC 2026: Of fairytales, inspiration and India

The Esports World Cup, a congregation of 25 titles, is just halfway through. And for India, **the contest starts now.**

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World Cups are always special, regardless of the sport. The fairytale run of underdogs punching well above their weight, the rise of a dark horse and the roar of fans echoing through the concrete to set the stage on fire.

The Esports World Cup, over the past month, has danced to the same tune.

The most compelling tale: Jaime "Craime" Bustos (**above**) — a 15-year-old prodigy from Chile becoming the youngest world champion in Street Fighter 6.

Though Craime looked like a kid in a crowd of veterans, he was hardly an unknown — he belonged to Team Falcons, one of the most decorated esports organisations.

But if there were still doubts about his ability, he erased them with a 3-0 win over AngryBird, who had finished fourth last year.

In the final, Craime faced Hibiki, a player twice his age, a multiple-time World No. 1, playing as Lily. But fairytales, as in most World Cups, refused to die an easy death.

And when the contest ended, Craime — playing as Ryu — was crowned champion after a 5-2 victory. What an irony for a player whose first competitive title was in a tournament called Never Give Up!

MOMENT IN THE SUN FOR INDIA?

The tournament, however, a congregation of 25 titles, is just halfway through. And for India, the contest starts now.

Four grandmasters — Nihal Sarin, Aravindh



From left: Aravindh Chithambaram, Pranesh M, Nihal Sarin and Arjun Erigaisi will have their eyes set on the EWC title.

Chithambaram, Pranesh M and Arjun Erigaisi — and two Indian esports organisations will be in action in chess at the World Cup, which boasts a prize pool of over INR 14.2 crore, and is scheduled from August 11 to 15.

Sarin, Aravindh and Pranesh will play for the Indian org. S8UL, Arjun Erigaisi for Korean-American club Gen.G Esports, while another Indian esports org., GodLike Esports, will field former World No. 12 Hans Niemann.

Away from the board, GodLike and Orangutan Esports from India will lock and load their rosters for PUBG Mobile, also known as BGMI.

GodLike, now without one of its stars, Jonathan Jude Amaral, will hope it has enough 'SPower' on its side, while Orangutan, having earned a direct spot in the grand finals with 91 points in the first group stage, will look to continue its dream run.

No Indian has ever lifted an Esports World Cup title so far, but then again, neither had the 15-year-old.